world not *against* the world: it is an alliance not for India's and China's betterment at the expense of others but rather for everyone's betterment. In the cosmopolitan view, the two societies would bring to global conversations an alternative to the dominant Western view of historical possibilities. Tagore and Nehru are the prophet-voices of such a view – and particularly Tagore. Tagore was one of the key figures in the discussions on pan-Asianism in the 1920s and 1930s which above all involved Indian, Chinese, and Japanese intellectuals and artists. In India, he more than anyone in modern times gave life to engagement across the Himalaya. In 1924, he visited China (to a mixed reception) to promote the idea of India–China engagement and pan-Asianism. In the 1920s, even as he was travelling in China, his school, Santiniketan, began hosting Japanese, European, and Chinese scholars interested in India–China interactions. In 1937, Tagore set up Cheena Bhavan at Santiniketan (with mostly Chinese money – Indian donations were meagre), to reinvigorate contact between the two kin civilizations. At any rate, the cosmopolitan view is of China as a partner in a new post-colonial world, reviving historical ties with India and deepening not just their mutual relations but also the world's moral and spiritual progress.

What, then, of India as an aspiring Great Power? Where does China appear in this worldview? Nehruvians and Hindu nationalists have their differences but neither viewpoint regards China as India's friend (though Nehru once did hope they could be): Great Powers are fated to mistrust and fear each other. In the Kautilyan view, India and China are rivals by virtue of geography: they are neighbours. In the Great Power view, it is not primarily geography that makes them rivals, it is the dynamic of power. As Great Powers they would be rivals, regardless of their location; geography merely adds to their rivalry. China can be expected to resist India's ascent and entry into the select club – just as the US seeks to resist China's ascent. Beijing would attempt to undermine Indian power materially but also symbolically deny it recognition as a Great Power. A key token of Great Power status is permanent veto-bearing membership of the United Nations